

Industry

People have always made and traded goods, but the late 18th century marked the beginning of the Industrial Revolution, when small workshops were replaced by large, machine-filled factories. Heavy industries such as steelmaking and shipbuilding employed whole towns of workers. Today, industry more often uses new technology and a small but skilled workforce to offer goods and services to customers near and far.



COTTAGE INDUSTRY

Despite the rise of modern manufacturing, many goods are still made by hand. Skilled workers like these potters make a living by producing things that local people need. They often make and sell their wares in areas of town that become known for certain types of products, such as leather bags and shoes on one street, and jewelry and metalwork on another.

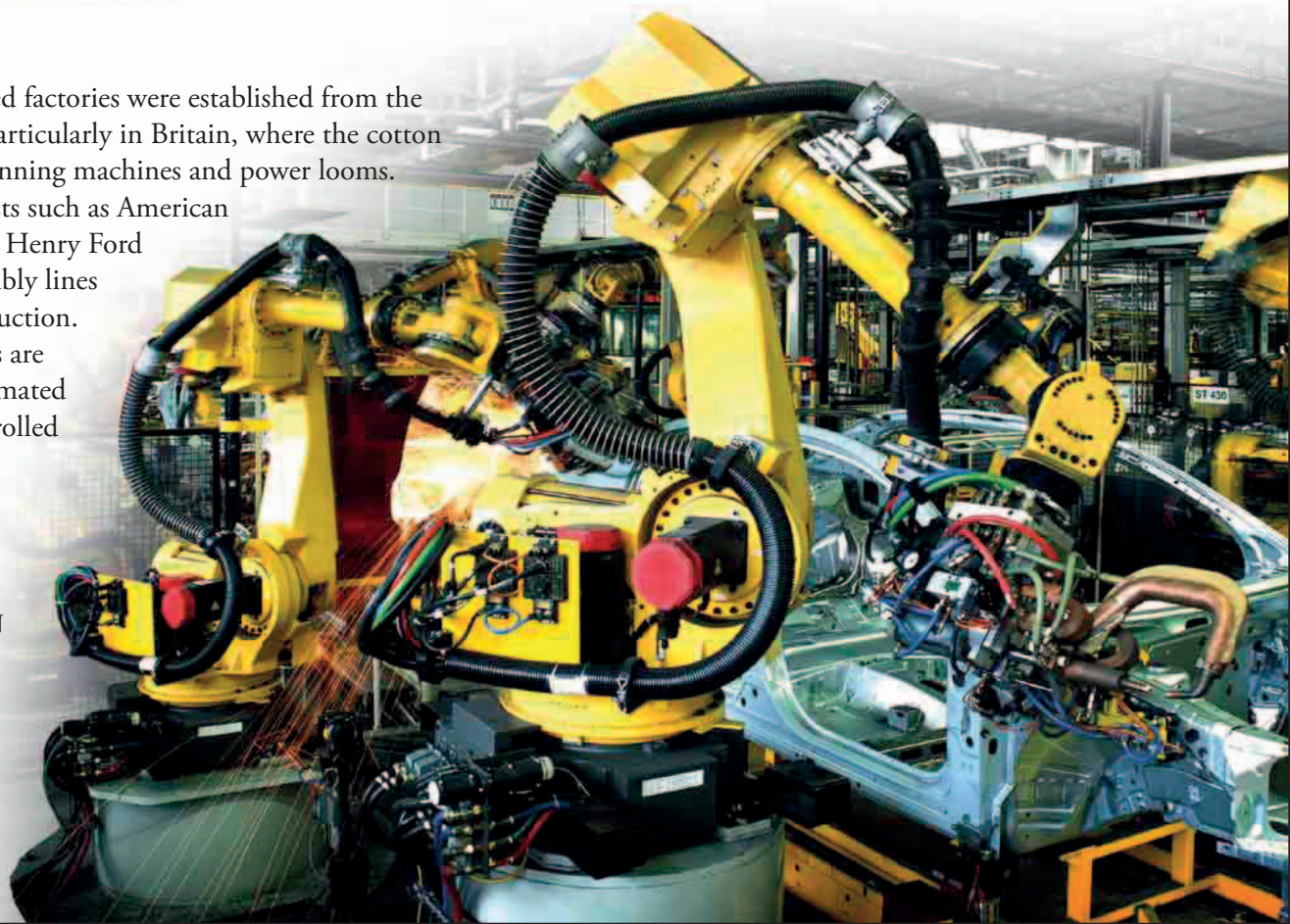
FACTORIES

Large, mechanized factories were established from the 1750s onward, particularly in Britain, where the cotton industry used spinning machines and power looms.

Later, industrialists such as American car manufacturer Henry Ford introduced assembly lines to speed up production. Today, these lines are often partly automated with robots controlled by computers.

► AUTOMATION

These welding robots in a car factory are fast and precise, and do not tire of doing the same task over and over again.



POWER

Early factories used waterwheels or large steam engines to provide the power for their machinery. Electric power is more convenient, because it can be used anywhere that can be connected to an electric cable. A constant, reliable supply of electricity is vital for modern industries, which depend more and more on computers and other electronic devices.

